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party to disband itself. Contending for power in an independent Indian state and assuming and using power in that state appalled and repelled him. In his last will and testament he called on Congress party workers to form a Lok Sevak Sangh where they could engage in constructive work in the towns and villages of India. Gandhi was a man of civil society dedicated to achieving individual and national swaraj, not to seizing and using state power. That was what Nehru wanted. In this context it made sense for Gandhi to tell Mountbatten that he should call on Jinnah to be the prime minister of the interim government, and for the Muslim League to form the government. Gandhi wanted India's independence, not Congress rule, and in that he didn't attract the kind of animosity and distrust that Jinnah directed at Nehru.



There are now no more points left to score; all have already been scored, no great issues of partition left to resolve, except one: an inability to understand what, after all, did this partition achieve? Other than constant pain and the suffering of crores of humans, all around, which has now finally moulded itself into a kind of a sealed and an abrasive continuity. This has become ours, India's proverbial cross, also perhaps its greatness. And as we end writing

about the epic journey of Mohammad Ali Jinnah from being the 'ambassador of Hindu-Muslim unity' to the Quaid-i-Azam of Pakistan, we need to share a reflection on a reality, that all historical narration is after all an account of the politics of those times. In which sense this attempt at Jinnah's political biography is exactly that, no more, no less. That notwithstanding, in the end, any assessment of who gained what in this traumatic partition becomes an empty exercise. For though Jinnah died in the after-glow of having found a 'new country', Pakistan, has remained a conceptual orphan, the result of a somewhat barren attainment; 'barren' because Pakistan itself, as both the progenitor and as the first born of the idea, has demonstrated that this notion of 'Muslims being a separate nation does not work'. It did so by breaking up on the issue of language; whereafter provincial identities and the many normal chores of routine, everyday existence like water or territory or boundary lines have asserted themselves.

The turbid sediment of our recent past, the agony of our blood encrusted partition continues to sour the present of Indo-Pak relations, still. Our sensibilities are now so splenetic that even the routine is a source of spiteful disbelief. Obviously, there is now no 'South Asian Monroe doctrine' of which Jinnah had spoken idealistically, instead we now have a near constant haze of simmering discord and mistrust. That is why I reflect: what if instead of this path of breaking apart and near continuous conflict, we had, instead, post the 1947 partition chosen to work together, to wipe out contentions and now that finally there has been born a sovereign Pakistan, to fraternally stop looking at the past? Would that have brought back that lost 'peace' to our region? I cannot vouchsafe the outcome; indeed, who can? For, along with several other there is one central difficulty that India, Pakistan, Bangladesh face: our 'past' has, in reality never gone into the 'past', it continues to reinvent itself, constantly becoming our 'present', thus preventing us from escaping the imprisonment of memories. To this we have to find an answer, who else can or will?

The partitioning of India is the defining event of the twentieth century for this entire subcontinent. The searing agony of it torments still, the whys and what-fors of it, too. We relive the partition because we persist without attempts to find answers to the great errors of those years so that we may never, ever repeat them. Also, perhaps by recounting them we attempt to assuage some of our pain.